

Foto: Dr. Matthias Otte

This work has been carried out within the framework of the EUROfusion Consortium and has received funding from the Euratom research and training programme 2014–2018 under grant agreement No. 633053. The views and opinions expressed herein do not necessarily reflect those of the European Commission.



EUROfusion

HELMHOLTZ

RESEARCH FOR GRAND CHALLENGES



IMPURITY TRANSPORT AND RADIATION AT THE STELLARATOR WENDELSTEIN 7-X

Promotionskolloquium

March 17, 2026

P. Scholl^{1,2}

¹Max Planck Institute for Plasma Physics,
Wendelsteinstr. 1, D-17491 Greifswald, Germany

²Ernst-Moritz-Arndt University Greifswald
Domstr. 11, D-17489 Greifswald, Germany

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Real-Time Radiation Feedback Control

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MOTIVATION

NUCLEAR FUSION: ENERGY CHALLENGE

- Lawson criterion for net energy gain:

$$n_e T \tau_E \geq \frac{12 f_{\text{tot}}}{\langle \sigma_{\text{DT}} v \rangle f_H^2 E_\alpha - 4 L_Z(T)} T^2$$

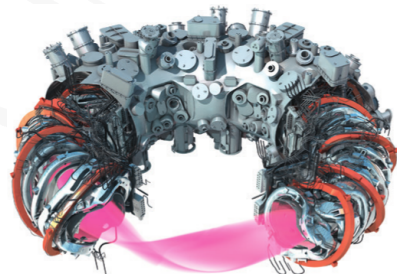
- Requires: high temperature ($T \sim 10 \text{ keV}$ to 20 keV), density, and confinement time

Triple Product

Key figure of merit for fusion performance combining density, temperature, and energy confinement time

WENDELSTEIN 7-X

- World's largest stellarator (major radius 5.5 m, minor radius 0.53 m)
- 70 superconducting magnets: 50 non-planar & 20 planar coils
- Volume 30 m^3 , $B_{\text{max}} = 3 \text{ T}$
- Island divertor configuration (5/6, 5/5, 5/4)
- Optimized for reduced neoclassical transport
- Heating power up to 14 MW ECRH



Key Challenge

Managing heat loads on plasma-facing components during long, high performance plasma

PLASMA RADIATION AND TRANSPORT

Transport Mechanisms:

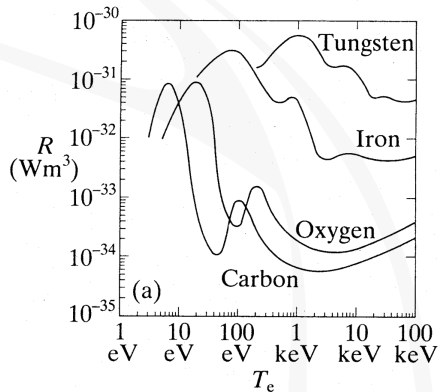
- Classical: collisional diffusion
- Neoclassical: trapped particles, $\propto 1/\nu$
- Anomalous: turbulence (dominant)

Radiation:

- Bremsstrahlung: $P_{\text{Brems}} \propto n_e^2 T^{1/2}$
- Line radiation: atomic transitions
- Impurity effects on plasma performance

Impurity Seeding

Injection of low-Z (He, N₂) or high-Z (Ne, Ar) impurities to enhance edge radiation and cooling

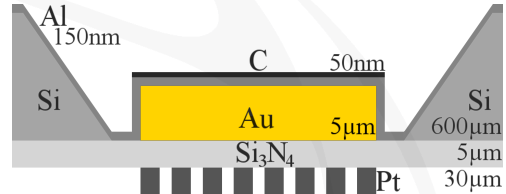


BOLOMETER DIAGNOSTIC

BOLOMETRY AT W7-X

Metal Resistor Bolometers:

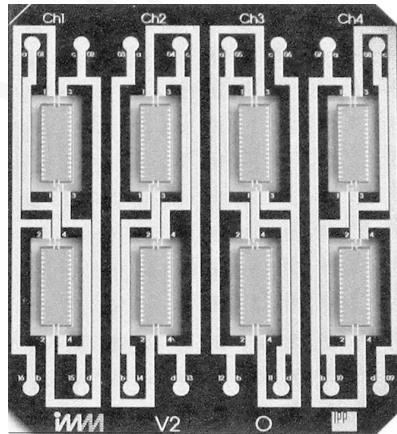
- Thin metal (gold) film absorbers
- Wheatstone bridge circuit configuration
- Measures total radiation power (broadband)
- Multicamera system: HBC & VBCI/r (32 + 2×24 channels)



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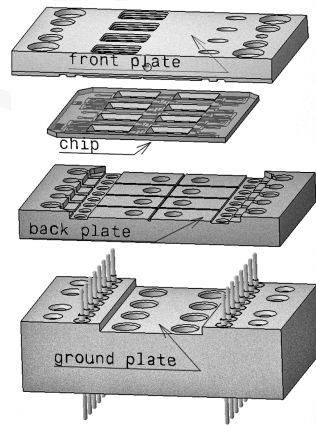
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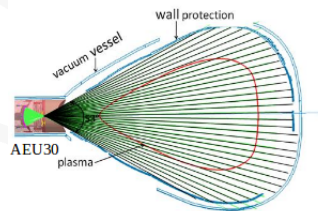
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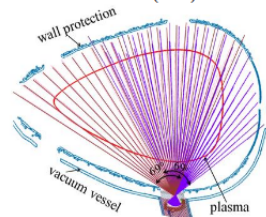
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horizontal bolometer camera (HBC)

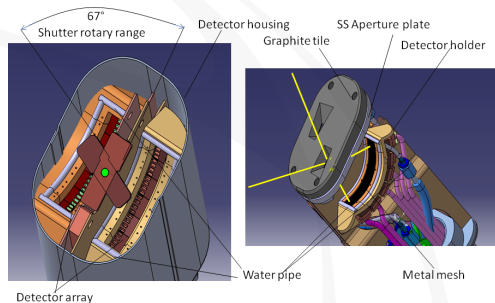


vertical bolometer camera (VBC)

BOLOMETRY AT W7-X

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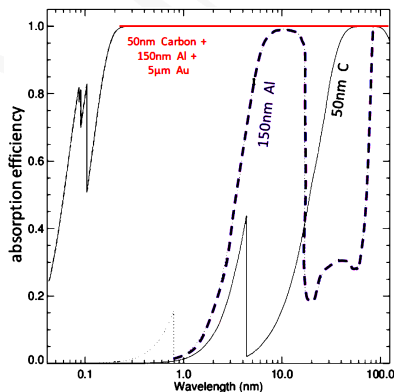
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PERFORMANCE

Performance Characteristics:

- In-situ ohmic heating calibration (F_M , f_M)
- Temporal resolution: $\{0.4, 0.8, 1.6, \dots, 6.4\}$ ms
- Measurement uncertainty (*Gauss*): $1.6 \mu\text{W} \leftrightarrow \text{SNR} > 1000$
- Spatial resolution: ~ 5 cm at magnetic axis
- Near unity absorption efficiency: 600-0.2 nm



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Power Per Detector:

$$P_M = F_M \cdot \left(\frac{d(\Delta \tilde{U}_M)}{dt} + f_M \Delta \tilde{U}_M \right)$$

Global Radiation Power:

$$P_{\text{rad}} = \frac{V_{\text{P,tor}}}{V_C} \sum_M \frac{P_M V_M}{K_M}$$

PERFORMANCE

Chord Brightness

Line-integrated measurement along each detector's line of sight provides radial profile information ($P_{\text{chord}} \sim P_M/K_M$)

Applications:

- Power balance calculations
- **Tomographic reconstruction**
- **Real-time feedback control**

→ **controlled radiative cooling in the plasma edge**

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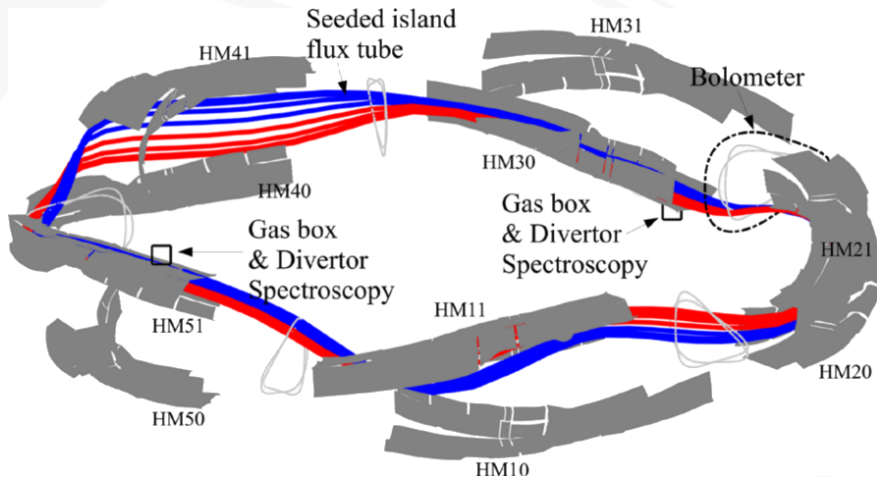
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REAL-TIME RADIATION FEED- BACK CONTROL

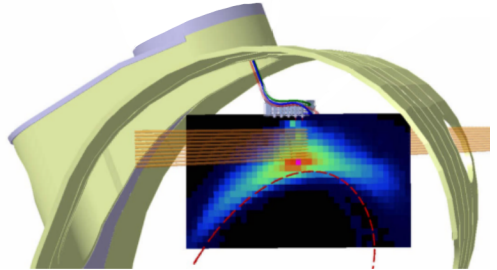
FEEDBACK SYSTEM



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Architecture:

- Integrated data acquisition hardware & optimized control software
- Twin proxies and dedicated signal outputs
- Thermal gas valve actuation with multipurpose/-diagnostic PID controller



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Radiation Prediction Proxies:

A: *Channel selection S*

$$P_{\text{pred}}^{(1)} = \frac{V_{\text{P,tor}}}{V_S} \sum_M^S \frac{P_M V_M}{K_M}$$

(e.g. $S_{\text{VBC}} = \{61, 86, 78, 73, 70, 65\}$)

B: *Single channel*

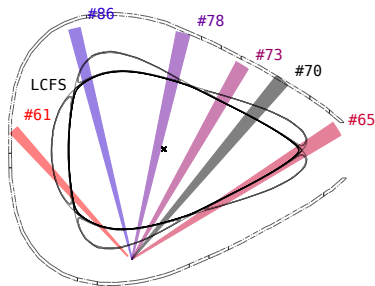
$$P_{\text{pred}}^{(2)} \propto \Delta \widetilde{U}_M$$

(dimensionless, minimal overhead)

FEEDBACK SYSTEM

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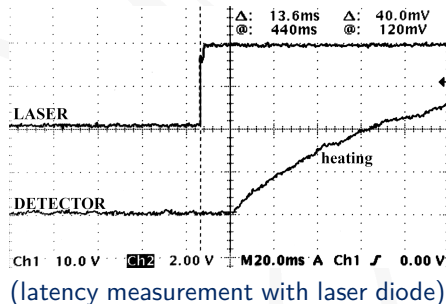
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FEEDBACK SYSTEM

System Performance:

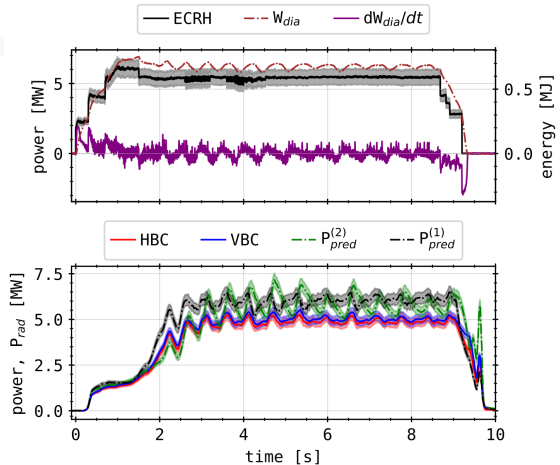
- FIFO smoothing in $P_{\text{pred}}^{(1)}$: $\sim M \cdot \Delta t / 2$ ($M=10$, $\Delta t=1.6$ ms)
- Minimum acquisition latency 13.6 ms
- Total system latency: 150 ms to 400 ms (dominated by plasma response)



EXPERIMENTAL ACHIEVEMENTS

XP20181010.32

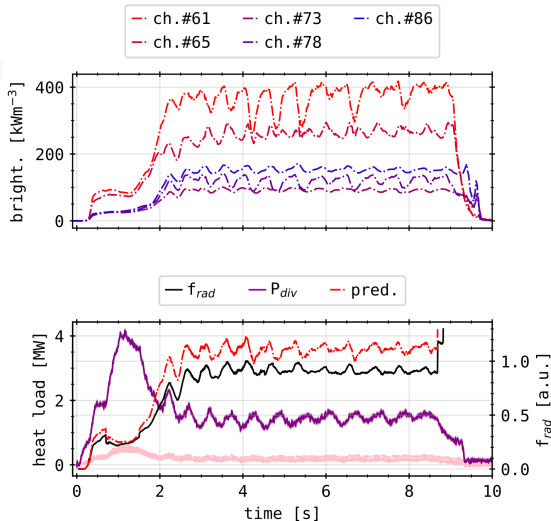
- Duration 9.2 s
 $P_{\text{ECRH}}^{\text{max}} = 6.23 \text{ MW}$ (O2-mode)
- Total input energy 55 MJ
- Radiation fraction PID
 setpoint $f_{\text{rad}} \sim 90\%$ off $P_{\text{pred}}^{(1)}$
- 5-channel VBC subset
 $S = \{65, 78, 61, 73, 86\}$



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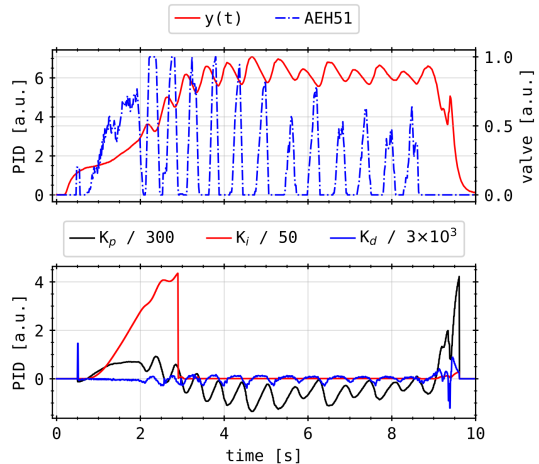
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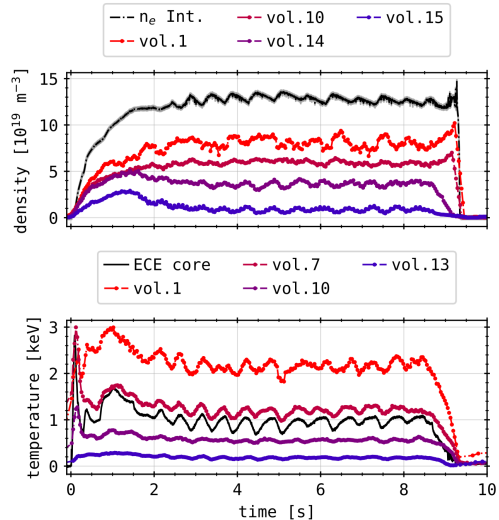
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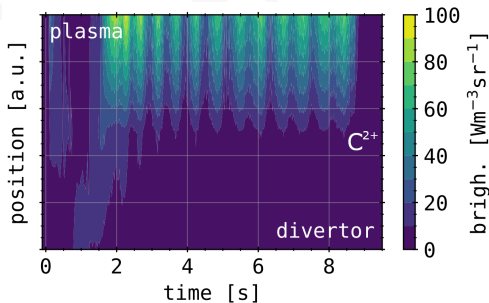
EXPERIMENTAL ACHIEVEMENTS

XP20181010.32

- Peak $f_{\text{rad}} \gtrsim 100\%$, cycling with gas inlet
- Target heat load reduction factor >2
- C^{2+} detachment visible at $f_{\text{rad}} \sim 50\%$

Key Result

Demonstrated stable, real-time feedback-controlled radiative cooling with $f_{\text{rad}} \geq 85\%$ without terminal plasma disruption and significant target heat load reduction



LINE OF SIGHT SENSITIVITY

CHANNEL SELECTION SENSITIVITY

- Evaluate LOS/channel efficacy for feedback (generalised local radiation sensitivity)
- Data set of all feedback discharges from OP1.2b
- Applied 5 different metric (linear & weighted deviation, FFT, ...)

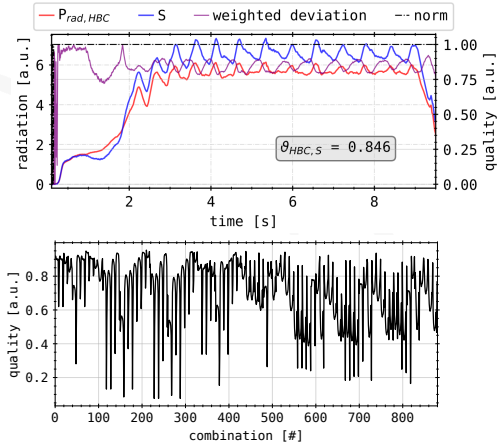
Weighted deviation:

$$\varphi(t) = 1 - \frac{\|P_{\text{pred}} - P_{\text{rad}}\|(t)}{P_{\text{rad}}(t)}$$

$$\vartheta = \frac{1}{T} \int_T \varphi(t) dt$$

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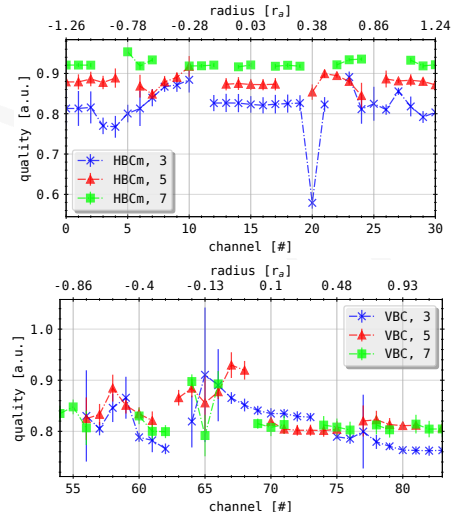
CHANNEL SELECTION SENSITIVITY

Optimal Channel Selection:

- No single "best" set exists
- Robust selection achieves $\geq 85\%$ prediction accuracy
- VBC channels generally outperform HBC for edge sensitivity
- 3-5 channels sufficient for reliable P_{pred}

Takeaway

Detectors viewing close to separatrix and SOL most viable for feedback purposes



TOMOGRAPHY

MINIMUM FISHER REGULARIZATION

Measurement:

$$\mathbf{T} \vec{x} = \vec{b}$$

Bolometer tomography:

- 61 line-integrated measurements $\vec{b}$
- 2D emissivity $\vec{x}$: ~ 4500 pixels
- *Geometry* $\mathbf{T}$ has high condition
- **ill-posed, requires regularization**

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Problem:

$$\min_{\eta} \left\| \left(\mathbf{T}^T \mathbf{T} + \mu^{-1} \mathbf{H} \right)^{-1} \mathbf{T}^T \vec{b} \right\| \rightarrow \vec{x}$$

Fisher Information:

$$I_F = \int \frac{1}{x} \left(\frac{\partial x}{\partial \vec{r}} \right)^2 d\vec{r} \leftrightarrow \mathbf{H} \sim \frac{1}{x} \Delta^T \Delta$$

limiting error on reconstruction:

$$\sigma_x \leq \frac{1}{I_F}$$

MINIMUM FISHER REGULARIZATION

MFR + RDA Advantages

- Robust to noisy data
- Incorporates a priori knowledge
- Stable convergence

Radially Dependent Anisotropy:

- Tailored weighting to poloidal gradient
- $k_{\text{ani}} < 1$: favours anisotropy
- $k_{\text{ani}} > 1$: favours smooth emissivity

$$\mathbf{H} \rightarrow \mathbf{H}_{\text{ani}}$$

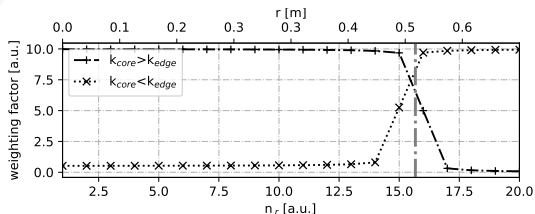
$$\Delta = \nabla_{\mathbf{r}}^{\mathbf{T}}(\cdot)\nabla_{\mathbf{r}} + \nabla_{\vartheta}^{\mathbf{T}}(\cdot)\nabla_{\vartheta}$$

$$\nabla_{\vartheta} \rightarrow \tilde{\nabla}_{\vartheta} = \frac{1}{k_{\text{ani}}\Delta r} \mathbf{D}_{\text{dia}}^{(0)} \nabla_{\vartheta}$$

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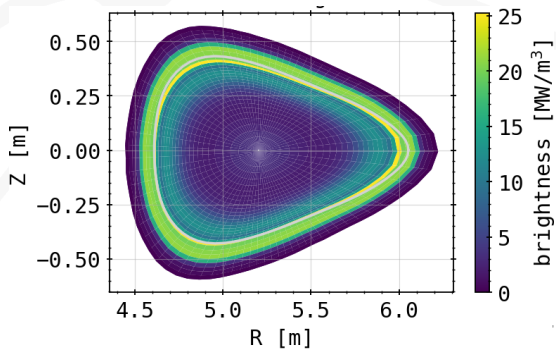
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BENCHMARKING

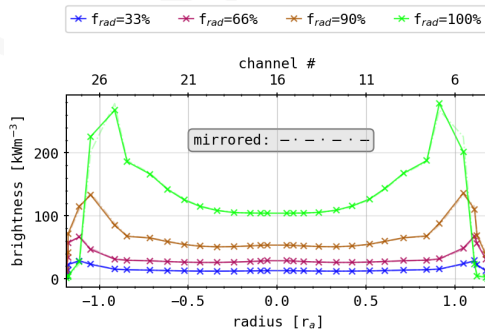
Geometry Perturbation Test:

- Previous and future calculations based on as-designed geometry
- Forward calculation of synthetic 2D emissivity show asymmetry (STRAHL)

BENCHMARKING



($f_{\text{rad}} \sim 100\%$)

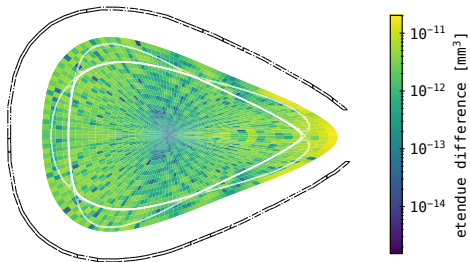
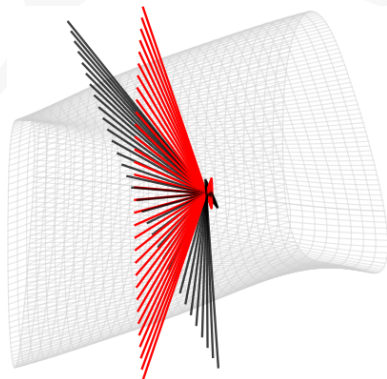


BENCHMARKING

Geometry Perturbation Test:

- Previous and future calculations based on as-designed geometry
- Forward calculation of synthetic 2D emissivity show asymmetry (STRAHL)
- Tests for symmetrical chord profile yield artificial camera geometry

BENCHMARKING

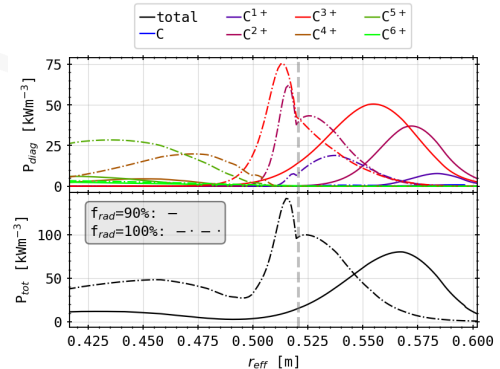




STRAHL IMPURITY TRANSPORT MODELING

STRAHL Code:

- 1D impurity transport and radiation simulation
- Solves radial continuity for each ionisation stage
- Experimental input data: perturbation study in transport coefficients, profile smoothing, source model etc.
- Valid in confinement, simple ansatz outside LCFS



STRAHL IMPURITY TRANSPORT MODELING

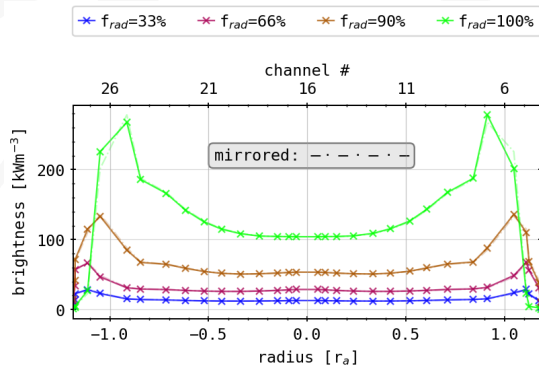
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Key Results:

- Carbon dominates emissivity ($C^{2/3+}$, $\times 10^2+$ of Oxygen levels)
- Inward shift of radiation for $f_{\text{rad}} \rightarrow 1$ toward $r \sim 0.95r_a$
- Radiation moves from outside to inside separatrix

STRAHL IMPURITY TRANSPORT MODELING



Forward Modeling:

- Chord brightness from STRAHL results
- Compare with experimental measurements
- Validate assumptions about impurity radiation and transport

Discrepancy

Forward calculations show asymmetry - less than experiments - in confinement, suggesting intrinsic geometry effects

STRAHL IMPURITY TRANSPORT MODELING

